

REFLECTION

A New Jahiliyyah?

Surah Hud 116 and the duty to stop corruption

Look at the world today and it can feel like the time before Islam, the *Jahiliyyah* (جَاهِلِيَّة, "the age of ignorance"). Injustice, lies, moral decay and corruption seem to be back with a vengeance, and Muslim societies have not been spared. What are we supposed to do?

In Surah Hud (11:116):

فَلَوْلَا كَانَ مِنَ الْقُرُونِ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ أُولُو بَقِيَّةٍ يَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْفَسَادِ فِي الْأَرْضِ إِلَّا قَلِيلًا مِّمَّنْ أَنجَيْنَا مِنْهُمْ ۗ وَاتَّبَعَ الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا مَا أُتْرِفُوا فِيهِ وَكَانُوا مُجْرِمِينَ ﴿١١٦﴾

"Why were there not, among the generations before you, people of virtue who spoke out against corruption on earth, except a few whom We saved? Those who did wrong went after the luxury they had been given, and they were guilty."

What the ayah teaches

- **The ones saved were the ones who spoke out:** يَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْفَسَادِ "they forbade corruption". Only "a few" did it, and those few were saved.

- **Comfort is a trap:** مَا أُتْرِفُوا فِيهِ "the luxury they were given". The others were busy enjoying life while the rot spread.
- **Silence is not neutral:** when a whole people is punished, those who watched and did nothing are not counted among the saved.

Allah is telling us to act, each in his own place: at home, at work, in the masjid, in how we vote and how we spend. We will be asked what we did.

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